



BY THIS SIGN CONQUER

THE BATTLE OF MILVIAN
BRIDGE (312 CE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The spread of Christianity

BEFORE

33 CE Crucifixion of Jesus.

46–57 Missionary journeys of St. Paul the Apostle.

64–68 CE When a fire breaks out in Rome, Emperor Nero kills hundreds of Christians as scapegoats; martyrdom of saints Peter and Paul.

284–305 Diocletian and Galerius suppress Christianity throughout the empire.

AFTER

325 The first Council of Nicaea defines the nature of orthodox Christian belief.

c. 340 Ulfilas, the “Moses of the Goths,” begins to spread Arian Christianity to the Germanic tribes.

380 Christianity becomes the Roman Empire’s official faith.

391 Pagan worship is banned in the Roman Empire.

In October, 312 CE, Emperor Constantine I was stationed at the Milvian Bridge near Rome, waiting to join battle with Maxentius, his rival for control of the Western Roman Empire (in 285, the empire had been split into two halves, eastern and western, each ruled by



Constantine I’s adoption of Christianity after his victory at the Milvian Bridge gave the faith a huge boost: it rapidly gained more followers and began edging out the pagan cults.

an emperor and a deputy). Tradition says that in the days before the encounter, Constantine had a vision of a flaming cross in the heavens bearing the inscription *in hoc signo vinces* (“by this sign conquer”). This convinced him that he had the support of the god of the Christians, and this belief was upheld when his army went on to defeat Maxentius’s men. In fact, the Christian god was not the first deity Constantine had auditioned; an earlier version of his vision had involved the Greek and Roman god Apollo. He appears to have been looking for theological “backup” to legitimize his ambition to become sole emperor, and a monotheistic supreme being may have seemed to him a good fit: a heavenly mirror image of his own position on Earth. Despite the legend of his divine vision, Constantine’s conversion to Christianity seems to have been gradual rather than immediate—he was not baptized until many years later, on